MENGYING WU
mengying_wu@hks.harvard.edu
617-800-4032
https://mengyingmandywu.github.io/

HARVARD UNIVERSITY

Address

Belfer Center 317
79 John F. Kennedy St.
Cambridge, MA 02138

Academic Appointments

Harvard University (2023 – Present)
Postdoctoral Fellow, Environment and Natural Resources Program, Harvard Kennedy School Belfer Center & Salata Institute for Climate and Sustainability

Carnegie Mellon University (2022 – 2023)
Postdoctoral Associate, Department of Engineering and Public Policy
Visiting Researcher, Institute of Energy, Environment, and Economy, Tsinghua University (2023)

Education

Massachusetts Institute of Technology, Institute for Data, Systems, and Society
Ph.D. in Social and Engineering Systems, 2023 (defended September 2022)

- Dissertation: *Local official and polluter accountability in China's environmental inspections*

M.Fin., MIT Sloan School of Management (2017)

Zhejiang University
B.S. in Applied Mathematics (2011–2015)

Fields

Environmental and Energy Economics; Political Economy of Regulation
Methods: equilibrium modeling; quasi-experimental designs; text as data

Fellowships

Salata Institute for Climate and Sustainability Postdoctoral Fellowship, Harvard University, 2023–2027
MIT Presidential Fellowship, 2017

Publications

Policy Interactions and the Cost of Decarbonizing Aviation (first author, with Kristen McCormack, William A. Scott, Aaron Smith, Jingran Zhang, and James H. Stock) [link] [code]
Journal of the Association of Environmental and Resource Economists, forthcoming (doi:10.1086/744324). NBER Working Paper No. 34326.
Policy impact: analysis of California's proposed SAF tax credit with this model was cited by the California Legislative Analyst's Office; covered by E&E News.

Dynamic Responses of SO_2 Pollution to China's Environmental Inspections (co-first author with Valerie J. Karplus) [link] [code]
Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences, 120(17): e2214262120, 2023.

Working Papers

The Binding Layer: What Stacked Federal and State Climate Policies Buy in U.S. Transportation Fuel [link]
Three climate policies cover U.S. transportation fuel: a federal biofuel mandate, a federal clean-fuel tax credit, and clean fuel standards in four states. Using a dynamic equilibrium model of fuel, feedstock, vehicle and credit markets for 2026–45, with credit holders' expectations and biofuel investment estimated and tested out of sample, I ask what this stack buys and at what cost. The federal mandate binds: it sets how much biofuel the country uses, so the tax credit and the state standards change emissions only through fuel prices, vehicle choice and where fuel is burned. About half of the cut inside the four states is renewable diesel pulled from other states. If EPA keeps the mandate at its 2027 level, extending the tax credit past 2029 lowers fuel prices and raises emissions by 33 to 67 million tonnes over 2026–45. Current law abates carbon at about $149 per tonne; a carbon price would buy the next 100 million tonnes at $36.

Research in Progress

Do State Low Carbon Fuel Standards Complement Federal Biofuel Mandates? (first author, with Kristen McCormack, William A. Scott, Aaron Smith, Jingran Zhang, and James H. Stock)
We study what state clean fuel standards add to federal biofuel mandates and how a state adopting one now should design it, in a model of fuel and vehicle markets with electric vehicle adoption and charging. In 2030, California's standard cuts fuel emissions in the state by about 32 million tonnes, but much of that cut is offset in other states as existing biofuel moves into California. It raises California's electric vehicle sales share from 21 to 33 percent. A new state that copies California's standard sits at its price cap unless it adds other credit types or a looser target.

When Inspectors Return: Who Receives Substantive Enforcement?
I study whom local governments penalize when China's central environmental inspectors return. Using case records for more than 80,000 citizen complaints across two inspection rounds, I find that shutdown orders for verified complaints against small service businesses fell from 45 to 22 percent, compared with 52 to 39 percent for heavy industry. The relative decline is about 36 percent and appears in all ten provinces, while the share of complaints found valid did not change. *Presented at the CU Environmental & Resource Economics Workshop, 2026.* It builds on two dissertation papers with Valerie J. Karplus and Lily L. Tsai.

Policy Writing

High Costs and Few Benefits from California's Proposed Sustainable Aviation Fuel Tax Credit (with Aaron Smith, Kristen McCormack, William A. Scott, James H. Stock, and Jingran Zhang) [link]
Energy Institute at Haas Blog, February 2026; cited by the California Legislative Analyst's Office.

Towards Credible and Cost-Effective Options for Sourcing Green Power for Supply Chains in China (with Da Zhang and Valerie J. Karplus) [link]
Policy brief for the Tsinghua Round Table on Corporate Carbon Neutrality Strategies, 2023.

Teaching & Advising

Research supervision, Harvard University (2026 – Present)
Supervise undergraduate research assistants on the clean-fuel policy modeling project.

Research supervision, Carnegie Mellon University (2022 – 2023)
Supervised master's research assistants on the Tsinghua green-power supply chain project (interview design, data collection, analysis).

Methods workshops, Carnegie Mellon University (2022 – 2023)
Led workshops for graduate students on web scraping and text analysis for building research datasets from administrative records.

The Economic Approach to Cities and Environmental Sustainability, MIT (Fall 2021)
Guest lecture: "Political Economy of Regulating Pollution"

Science, Technology and Public Policy, MIT (Spring 2020, Spring 2021)
Teaching Assistant for Professors Noelle Selin and Kenneth Oye; led weekly recitation sections (10–15 students), grading, and research-project mentoring.

MIT Kaufman Teaching Certificate Program, MIT (Fall 2020)
Designed course curriculum for "Data Science for Decision Making in Public Policy".

Academic Talks

2027 ASSA Annual Meeting (poster, scheduled)

2026 APPAM Fall Research Conference; ENRP/STPP Fellows Seminar, Belfer Center; Salata Institute Transportation Lab; Tsinghua University; CU Environmental & Resource Economics Workshop; University of Hong Kong; Hong Kong University of Science and Technology; ARCS Research Conference; Renmin University of China; China and Energy Fellows Seminar, Belfer Center; Fudan University; Huazhong University of Science and Technology; Institutional and Organizational Economics Academy; CES NA Annual Conference

	2024	ASSA Annual Meeting
	2023	ARCS Annual Research Conference
	2022	Northeast Workshop on Energy Policy and Environmental Economics
	2020–21	Environmental Politics and Governance Conference; Duck Family Graduate Workshop in Environmental Politics and Governance (2020, 2021); Institutional and Organizational Economics Academy; ETH Academy on Sustainability and Technology; China Research Group Doctoral Symposium; Interdisciplinary Ph.D. Workshop in Sustainable Development
Policy & Industry Talks	2026	North American SAF Conference and Expo; International Fuel Ethanol Workshop & Expo
	2025	Regional SAF Workshop for Massachusetts and New England
	2024	North American SAF Conference and Expo
	2023	Roundtable on Corporate Carbon Neutrality Strategies, Tsinghua University

Service

Student organizer, Sloan China Seminar Series, MIT (2017–2020)
Research Collaborator, Sustainable PPE Initiative, MIT (2020–2021)

Languages

English (fluent), Chinese (native)

Software skills

Python, Stata, R, MATLAB, LaTeX

References

James H. Stock
Harold Hitchings Burbank Professor of Political Economy
Vice Provost for Climate and Sustainability
Harvard University
79 John F. Kennedy St, Belfer 504
Cambridge, MA 02138
james_stock@harvard.edu

Valerie J. Karplus
Professor of Engineering and Public Policy
Associate Director, Wilton E. Scott Institute for Energy Innovation
Carnegie Mellon University
5123 Scott Hall, 5000 Forbes Ave
Pittsburgh, PA 15213
vkarplus@andrew.cmu.edu

Aaron Smith
Gordon Rausser Distinguished Chair and Professor of Agricultural and Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
207 Giannini Hall
Berkeley, CA 94720
AaronSmith@berkeley.edu